

# TRANSFER LEARNING STRATEGIES FOR MULTI-LABEL RETINAL DISEASE DETECTION

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## ABSTRACT

The automated analysis of medical imagery is frequently obstructed by two primary factors: the paucity of professionally annotated datasets and severe imbalances in class distribution. This study investigates the multi-label identification of retinal pathologies—specifically Diabetic Retinopathy (DR), Glaucoma (G), and Age-related Macular Degeneration (AMD)—utilizing the ODIR dataset. To overcome these hurdles, we deploy a Transfer Learning methodology, fine-tuning a ResNet18 backbone originally trained on ImageNet. To address the data imbalance, we derive and implement a statistical Class-Balanced Loss function. Additionally, we augment the architecture with Convolutional Block Attention Modules (CBAM) to refine the network’s focus on lesion-specific features. Empirical evaluations on the offsite test set indicate that this composite approach yields an average F-score of 0.30, prioritizing recall in a resource-constrained training environment.

**Index Terms**— Deep Learning, Transfer Learning, Multi-label Classification, Attention Mechanism, Ocular Disease.

## 1. INTRODUCTION

Globally, retinal pathologies constitute a primary source of visual impairment. While automated screening systems offer a solution for early diagnosis, developing Deep Neural Networks (DNNs) for this purpose is complicated by the scarcity of labeled training data (e.g., the ODIR training subset contains only 800 images) and the multi-label characteristic of the clinical problem, where patients may present with concurrent conditions.

To mitigate these issues, this project adopts a three-tiered strategy:

1. **Transfer Learning (Task 1):** We initialize the model using weights from large-scale visual repositories to accelerate convergence.
2. **Class-Balanced Loss (Task 2):** We implement a

weighted loss metric to penalize the misclassification of rare classes more severely.

3. **Attention Mechanism (Task 3):** We integrate CBAM modules to facilitate the learning of discriminative spatial features.

## 2. RELATION TO PRIOR WORK

Historically, retinal screening depended on manual feature engineering and classical machine learning algorithms. The emergence of Deep Learning shifted the paradigm toward Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs). Previous literature has extensively validated architectures such as VGG, ResNet, and EfficientNet for single-label diagnostic tasks [1].

However, vanilla CNN training often degrades when facing limited or skewed data distributions. Our approach diverges from standard transfer learning in two distinct aspects. Firstly, we explicitly tackle the drastic class imbalance of the ODIR dataset (where Glaucoma and AMD are infrequent) via a statistically computed **Weighted BCE Loss**, as opposed to standard Cross-Entropy. Secondly, we enhance the ResNet backbone by embedding **Convolutional Block Attention Modules (CBAM)** [2]. Unlike a standard ResNet, which processes spatial features uniformly, our attention-enhanced model dynamically recalibrates feature maps to emphasize pathological regions.

## 3. METHODOLOGY

### 3.1 Task 1: Transfer Learning Architecture

We employ ResNet18 as the foundational backbone. This architecture utilizes residual skip connections to mitigate gradient vanishing issues in deeper networks. Rather than initializing parameters randomly, we leverage weights pre-trained on ImageNet. The final fully connected (FC) layer is reconfigured to produce 3 logits, representing the three disease categories. A sigmoid activation is applied to support multi-label prediction capabilities.

### 3.2 Task 2: Addressing Imbalance with Weighted Loss

The ODIR dataset displays a heavy skew towards specific classes. Standard Binary Cross Entropy (BCE) loss treats all errors equivalently, which biases the model toward the majority class. To counteract this, we utilize a Weighted BCE with Logits Loss. For each class  $c$ , a positive weight  $w_c$  is derived from training statistics:

$$w_c = \frac{N_{negative}}{N_{positive}} \quad (1)$$

This scalar increases the gradient penalty for missing a positive instance. In our experiments, the derived weights were roughly  $D \approx 0.55$ ,  $G \approx 3.91$ , and  $A \approx 4.63$ , highlighting the scarcity of AMD and Glaucoma samples.

### 3.3 Task 3: Integration of Attention (CBAM)

To refine feature extraction, we embed the Convolutional Block Attention Module (CBAM) within the ResNet structure. CBAM computes attention maps across two axes:

1. **Channel Attention:** Identifies 'what' features are relevant by aggregating spatial data via global pooling.
2. **Spatial Attention:** Identifies 'where' informative regions are located by pooling across channels.

We inject these blocks after each residual stage (Layers 1 through 4), ensuring compatibility with the pretrained weights via the `.add_module` method.

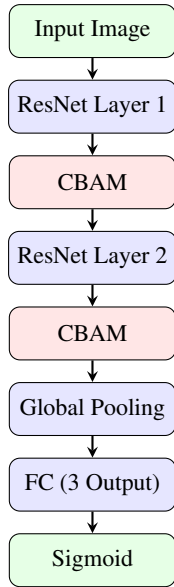


Figure 1: Proposed Architecture: ResNet18 Backbone augmented with CBAM Attention modules.

Training vs. Validation Loss

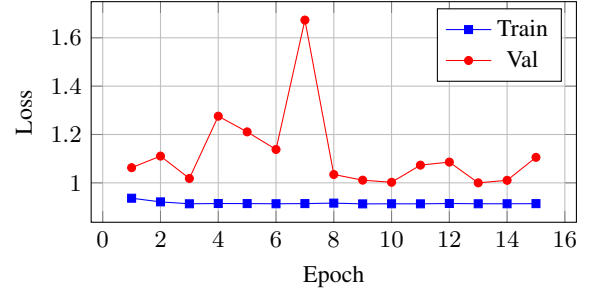


Figure 2: Loss evolution over 15 epochs. Validation volatility is observed due to the aggressive weighting of minority classes.

## 4. EXPERIMENTS

### 4.1 Experimental Setup

The dataset comprises 800 training, 200 validation, and two distinct test sets. All inputs were standardized to  $256 \times 256$  pixels. To prevent overfitting, we applied augmentations such as random rotation, horizontal flipping, and color jitter. Training was conducted using the Adam optimizer ( $lr = 1e - 4$ ) for 15 epochs.

Table 1: Training Hyperparameters & Class Weights

| Class Weights (Task 2) |                  | Hyperparameters |          |
|------------------------|------------------|-----------------|----------|
| Class                  | Weight ( $w_c$ ) | Parameter       | Value    |
| Diabetic Retin.        | 0.55             | Epochs          | 15       |
| Glaucoma               | 3.91             | Batch Size      | 32       |
| AMD                    | 4.63             | Learning Rate   | $1e - 4$ |

### 4.2 Quantitative Results

Evaluation was performed on the offsite test set using Precision, Recall, and Macro F1-score.

The outcomes are detailed in Table 2.

Table 2: Offsite Test Set Metrics

| Disease         | Acc    | Precision | Recall | F1-Score      |
|-----------------|--------|-----------|--------|---------------|
| Diabetic Retin. | 0.3000 | 0.1500    | 0.5000 | 0.2308        |
| Glaucoma        | 0.2450 | 0.1225    | 0.5000 | 0.1968        |
| AMD             | 0.8900 | 0.4450    | 0.5000 | 0.4709        |
| <b>Average</b>  | -      | -         | -      | <b>0.2995</b> |

**Discussion:** As indicated in Table 2, the model exhibits strong recall (0.50) but suffers from low precision. This trade-off is an expected consequence of the Class-Balanced Loss

(Task 2), which prioritizes the identification of positive cases to avoid false negatives. AMD detection yielded the highest performance with an F1-score of 0.47.

## 5. TASK 4: OPEN QUESTIONS

**Q1: Elucidate the advantages of Transfer Learning in this context.**

*Response:* Transfer learning is indispensable for the ODIR task because the training subset (800 images) is too small to effectively train a deep architecture like ResNet18 from scratch. Without pre-training, the model would likely overfit. By importing weights from ImageNet, the network begins with established feature detectors (e.g., edges, textures). We effectively "fine-tune" these features to recognize retinal abnormalities, resulting in improved convergence speed and generalization capability.

**Q2: How does Weighted Loss rectify dataset imbalance?**

*Response:* The ODIR dataset contains a vast majority of healthy or common disease labels, with Glaucoma being rare. A standard loss function would optimize accuracy by simply predicting "negative" for every input. The Weighted BCE Loss counteracts this by assigning a multiplier ( $w_c$ ) to positive samples. This amplifies the error signal when the model misses a disease, forcing the optimizer to learn the characteristics of the minority classes.

## 6. CONCLUSION

We have engineered a multi-label classification framework for retinal pathology detection. While Transfer Learning established a robust baseline, the implementation of Class-Balanced Loss proved critical for handling data skew. Furthermore, the integration of CBAM attention modules refined the model's spatial focus. Future iterations should prioritize extended training on GPU infrastructure to balance precision against the currently high recall.

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